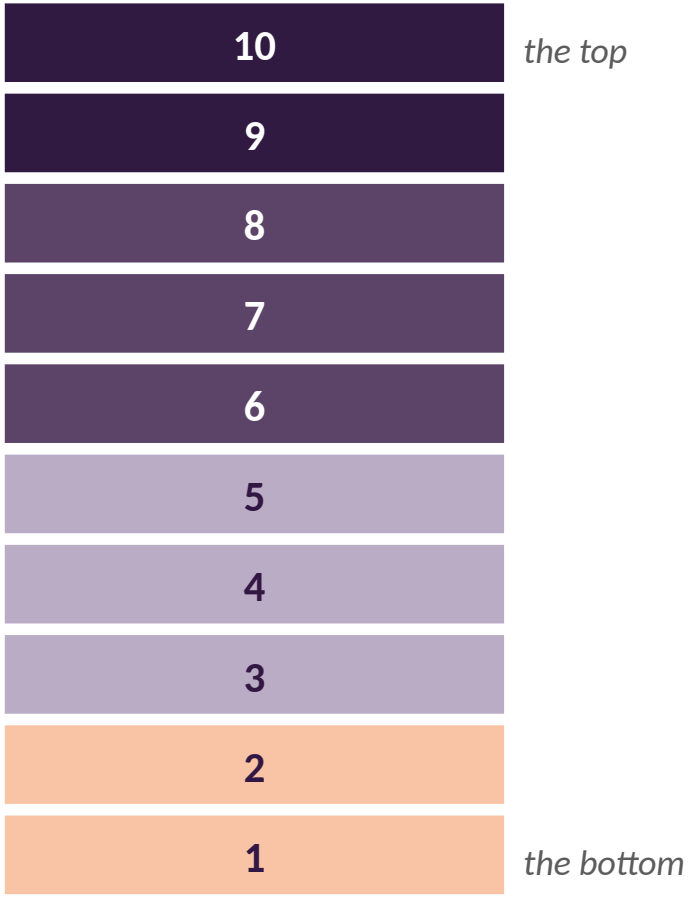
POSC 3710: European Politics

11/9/2026: THE RADICAL RIGHT IN POWER

DR. WILL HORNE

CLEMSON UNIVERSITY

Subjective social status: the ladder



THE SURVEY QUESTION

"In our society, some groups are more on top and others are more at the bottom. Thinking about yourself, where would you place yourself in this scale?"

WHAT IT MEASURES

"The level of social respect or esteem people believe is accorded them within the social order."

Asked in the same words in many countries since 1987, so the answers can be compared across countries and over time.

What Gidron and Hall find

6% → 11%

The predicted chance of a vote for the populist right, moving from medium-high to medium-low status

10 of 12

Countries where men without a college degree rank lower, relative to everyone else, than 25 to 30 years earlier

9 of 12

Countries where women's status rose relative to men's over the same years

Their claim is a modest one: status is "one pathway" by which economic and cultural change reach the ballot box.

Two roads to lower status

THE ECONOMIC ROAD

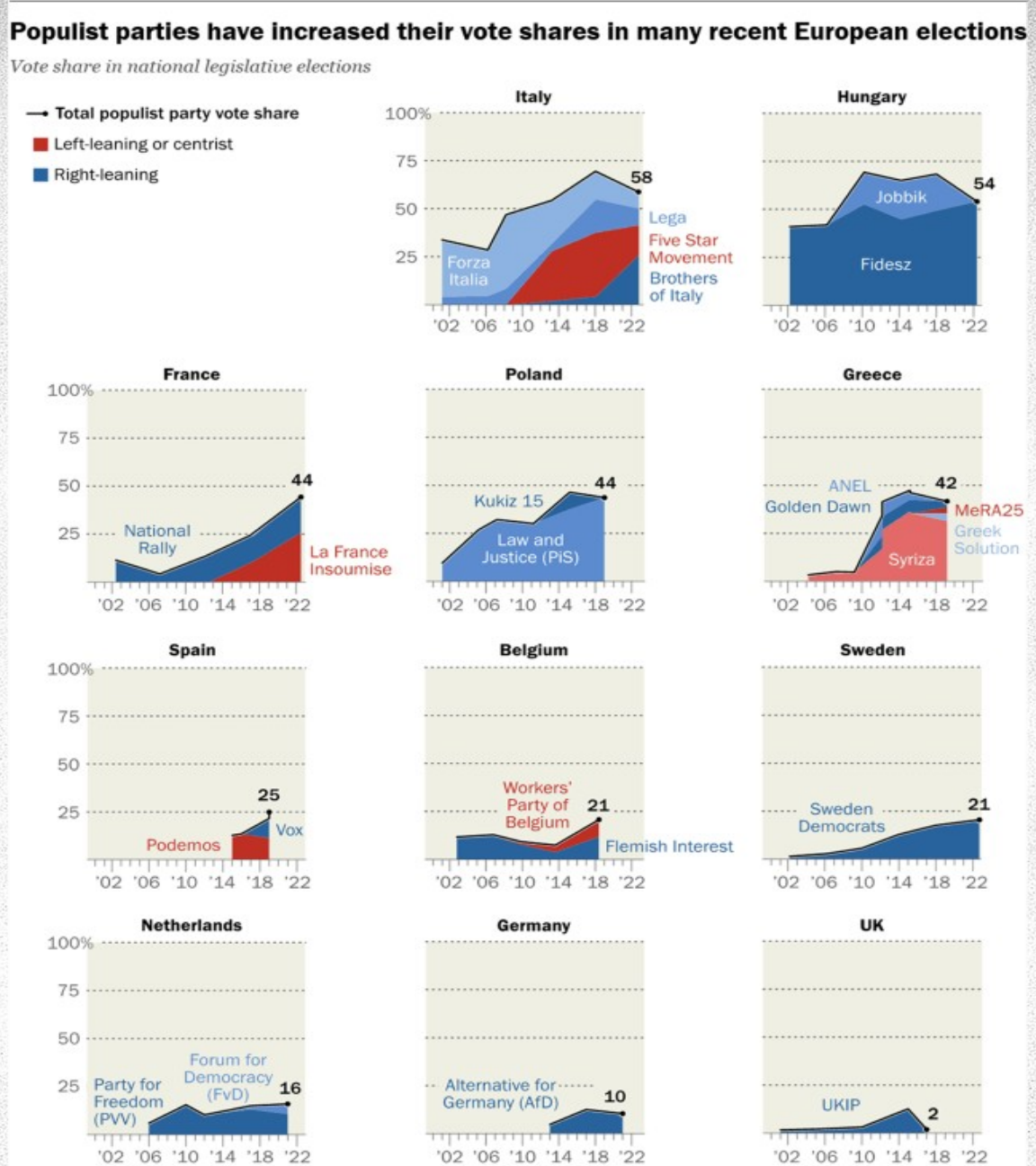
- "The gradual disappearance of low-skilled decent jobs"
- Part-time and temporary work in their place

THE CULTURAL ROAD

- Esteem goes to skills and degrees: "It is no longer enough to be a hard worker."
- Women in paid work, ages 25 to 54: 54% in 1980, 71% in 2010

LOWER STANDING
for people (particularly men) without a college degree

SUPPORT FOR THE POPULIST RIGHT
"Threats to a person's social status evoke feelings of hostility to outgroups."


Populist parties have increased their vote shares in many recent European elections
Vote share in national legislative elections
Total populist party vote share
Left-leaning or centrist
Right-leaning
Italy
100%
75
50
25
58
Lega
Five Star Movement
Brothers of Italy
Forza Italia
'02 '06 '10 '14 '18 '22
Hungary
54
Jobbik
Fidesz
France
44
National Rally
La France Insoumise
Poland
44
Kukiz 15
Law and Justice (PiS)
Greece
42
ANEL
Golden Dawn
MeRA25
Greek Solution
Syriza
Spain
25
Podemos
Vox
Belgium
21
Workers' Party of Belgium
Flemish Interest
Sweden
21
Sweden Democrats
Netherlands
16
Party for Freedom (PVV)
Forum for Democracy (FvD)
Germany
10
Alternative for Germany (AfD)
UK
2
UKIP
Note: Data presented is only for 2000-2022; some of these parties have competed in elections and won vote share for longer than that period. Party list vote is used for Germany; first-round results are used for France. For more on European populist parties, see Appendix.
Source: ParlGov, Swedish Election Authority and the Guardian.
PEW RESEARCH CENTER

Source:
Pew

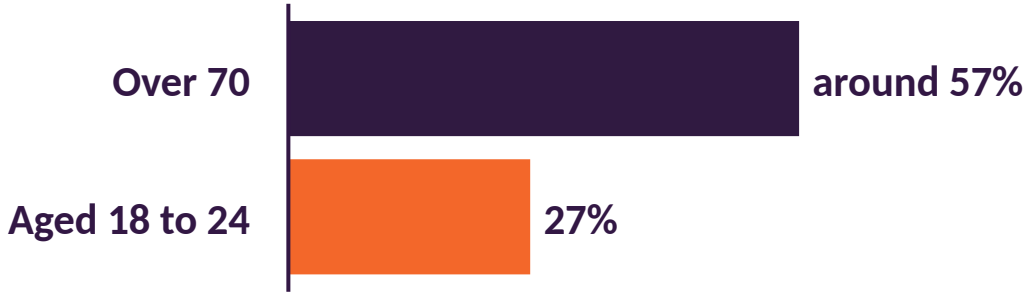
France, April 2022: who votes against the system?

HANDS UP

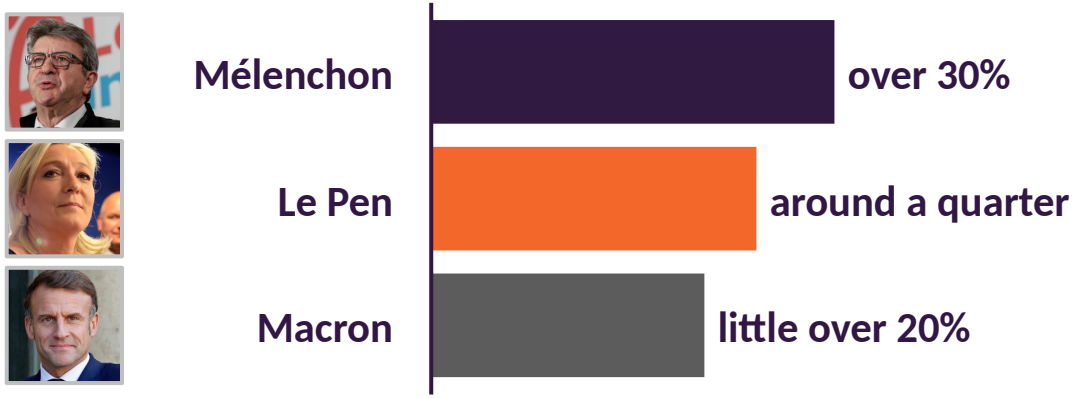
In France, who backs Le Pen more?

Voters over 60 | Voters under 60

Vote for Macron and the other mainstream candidates, first round of the presidential election



Voters under 35: the three leading candidates



Emmanuel Macron, president of France since 2017. Marine Le Pen, of the National Rally, on the radical right. Jean-Luc Mélenchon, of France Unbowed, on the radical left.

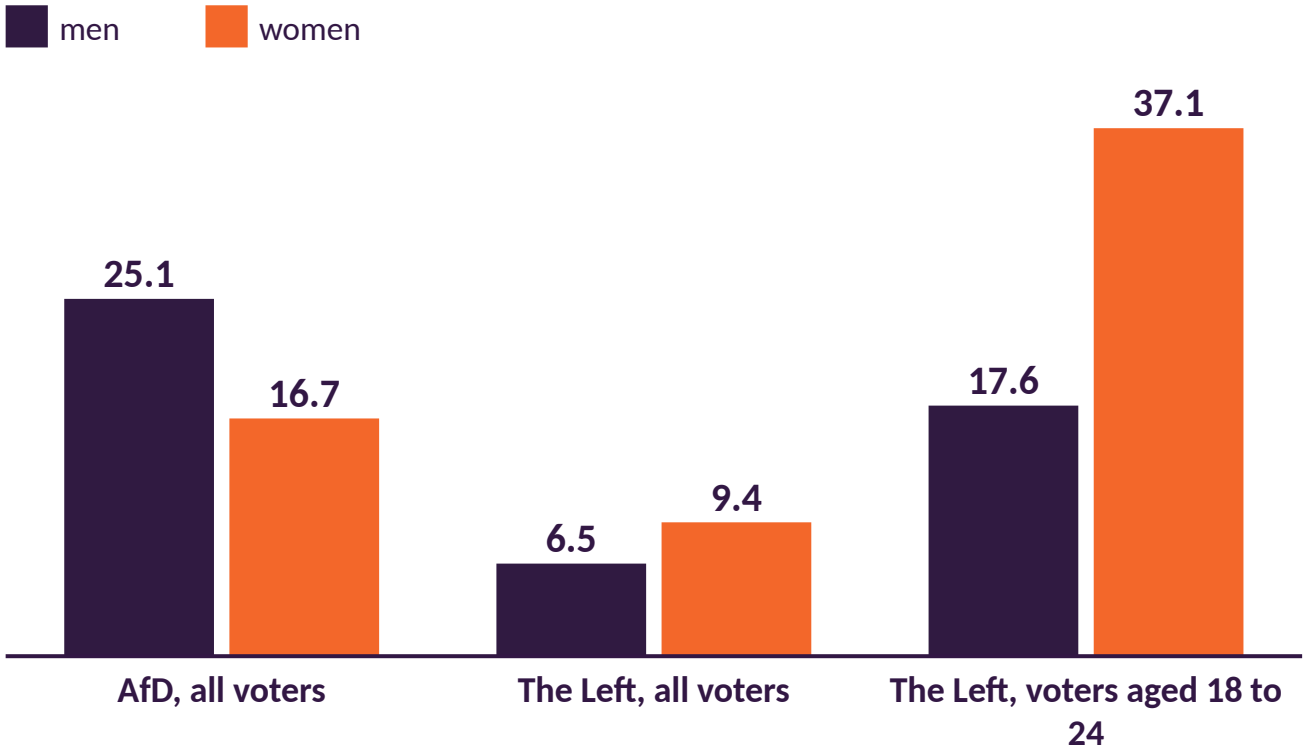
The finding: youth predicts a vote against the system, on the left and on the right. Support for the mainstream grows with age.

Are these Männerparteien [men's parties]?

THE PATTERN

- The first leaders were all men, and so were nearly all their members of parliament
- These parties have always done better among men than among women
- Often anti-feminist, and for traditional roles
- Women vote further left than men

Germany's election of February 2025: the share of men and of women who voted for each party (%)



On the other hand...



Marine Le Pen, France

Leader of the National Rally in parliament; a candidate for president in 2027



Giorgia Meloni, Italy

Leader of the Brothers of Italy; prime minister since 2022



Alice Weidel, Germany

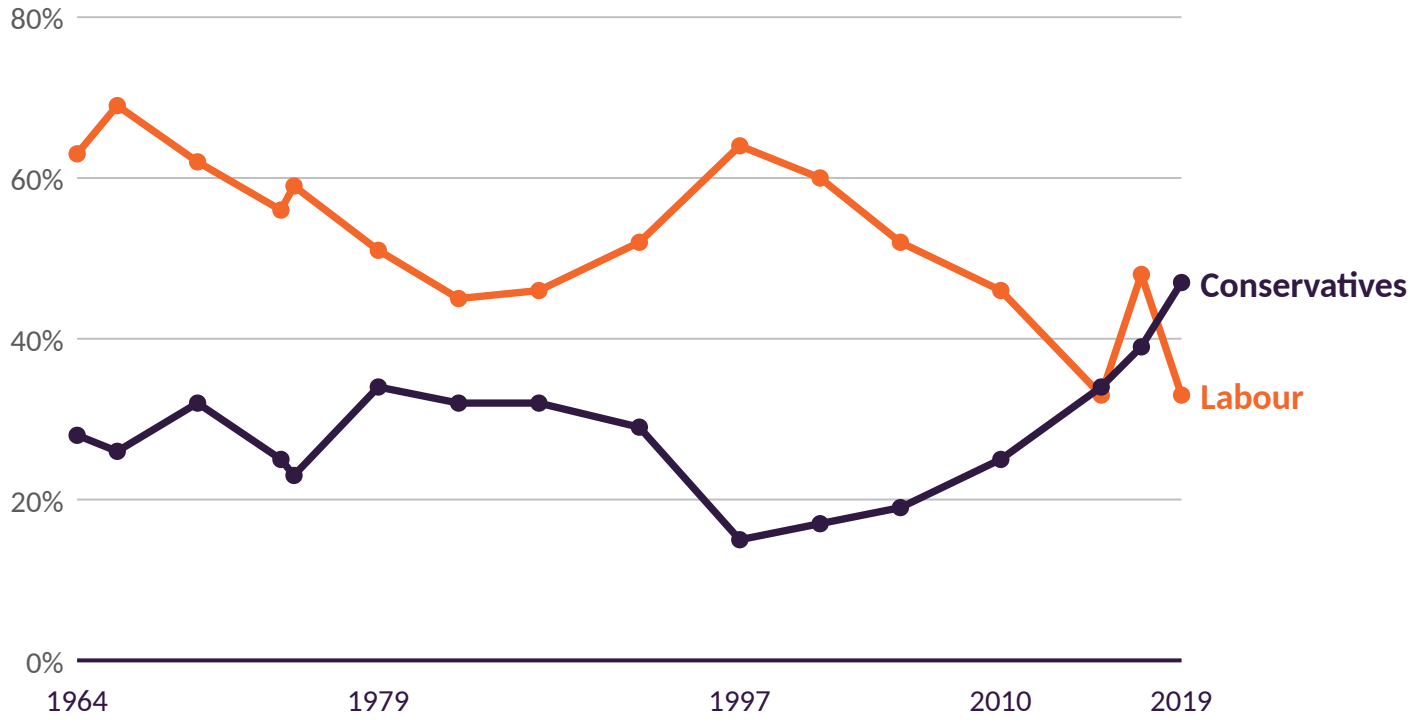
Co-leader of the AfD, re-elected in July 2026

ASK THE ROOM

Why would a radical right party want a woman at the top?

Britain’s working-class voters: did they leave Labour, or did the party leave them?

How working-class voters voted at general elections (%)



WHY THE LEFT MOVED

- Working-class voters were once a majority. In most countries they are now far from one
- Many live in safe city seats or in declining towns
- They lean left on the economy and right on social issues. Middle-class voters: the reverse
- The change is starkest under first-past-the-post

Could the left win them back with more working-class candidates?

Yes **No**

In 2019 the Conservatives led Labour among working-class voters, about 47% to 33%.

More recent waves: Moderation and Breakthrough

- In recent years, right populist parties have started to be structured more like normal parties, rather than vehicles for charismatic populist politicians
- Parties have made a serious attempt to clean up their image, kicked out most extreme and racist politicians, moved away from anti-semitism
- To some extent, this has been successful. Populist right parties have joined several governments, and their vote share has dramatically increased.

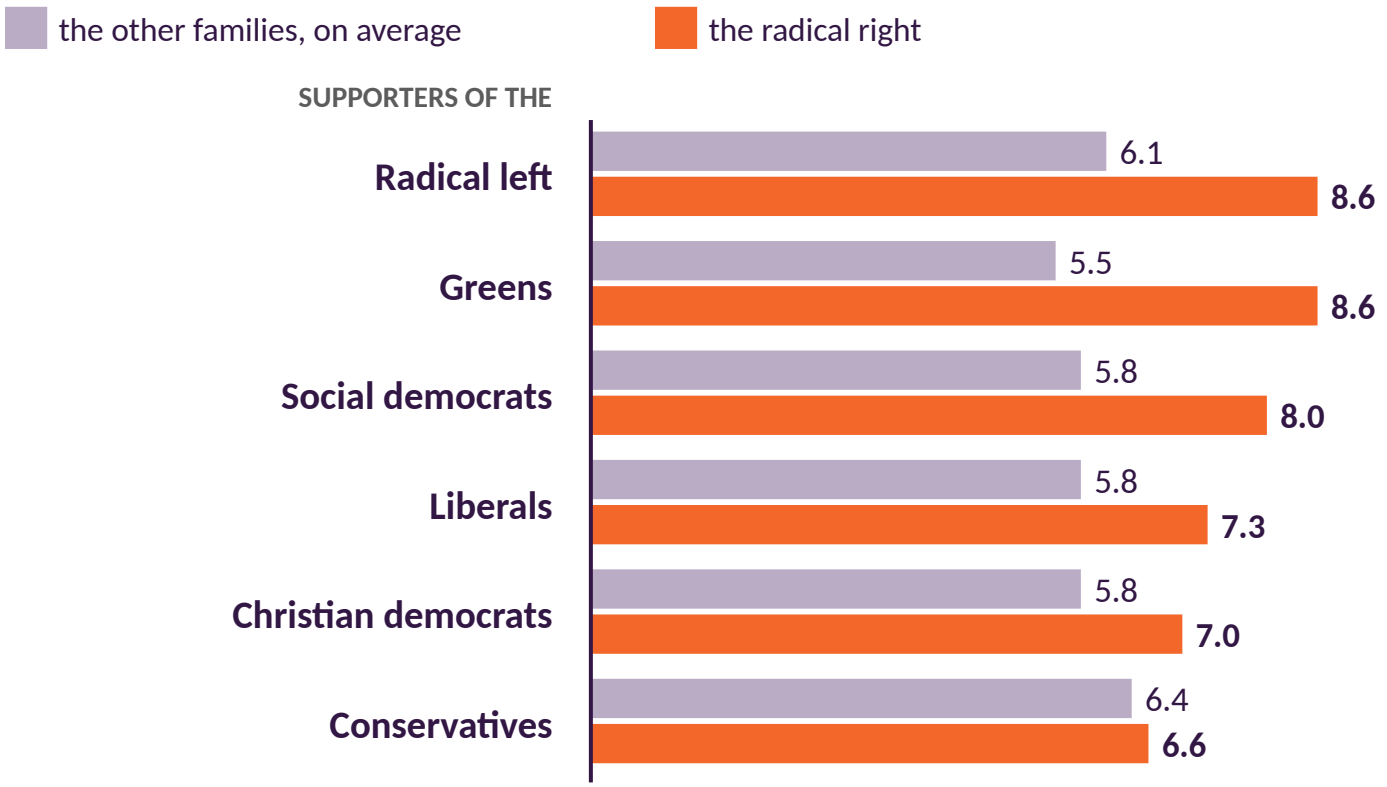
How do the mainstream parties interact with the populist right?

SHUT IT OUT	LET IT GOVERN	TAKE UP ITS POSITIONS
No coalition, no deals	**In the cabinet, or supporting it from outside**	**Compete for its voters**
• Germany: the “firewall” around the AfD • Belgium: a cordon around the Flemish radical right for more than thirty years • France: rivals stand down in the runoff	• Austria in 2000 and 2017 • Italy since 2022, Finland since 2023 • From outside: Denmark from 2015 to 2019, Sweden from 2022 to 2026	• Meguid’s “accommodative” strategy, from November 2 • Denmark’s Social Democrats, on immigration • Mudde’s warning: it can make the challenger stronger

Which did the FRC choose?

Why shut them out? Everyone else dislikes them

How much the supporters of each party family dislike the other families (0 = like, 10 = dislike)



THE PENALTY

1.47 points

How much more a radical right party is disliked than its policy positions and its coalition record would predict

Its own supporters dislike the other families at 6.4, on average

This is what my co-authors and I find: election surveys in 20 Western democracies, 1996 to 2017.

Germany's firewall

THE RULE

- The Brandmauer: "all parties have refused to cooperate with the AfD"
- The CDU's own rule since 2018: no coalition with the AfD, and none with the Left
- January 2025: a CDU motion on migration passed with AfD votes, 348 to 345

THE STRAIN

- The AfD in the west, March 2026: 18.8% in Baden-Württemberg, "around 20 percent" in Rhineland-Palatinate
- Among blue-collar workers: "nearly 40 percent"
- Polls: "nearly half of voters in southwestern Germany now open to cooperation"

THE DILEMMA

- "How can center-right majorities in public opinion be translated into policy when doing so requires cooperation with the political left?"
- Some conservatives call the firewall a "straitjacket"



Friedrich Merz, leader of the CDU and chancellor of Germany since May 2025. He has ruled out a coalition with the AfD

Michael Bröning is a political scientist and sits on a commission of Germany's Social Democrats.

ACTIVITY

Saxony-Anhalt, September 6, 2026: you lead the CDU

You are Sven Schulze, the CDU minister-president of this German state. 83 seats; 42 make a majority.



The AfD won 43.8% of the vote. The BSW is a new party, left on the economy and against immigration.

A. EVERYONE BUT THE AFD

- CDU, SPD, Greens, the Left and BSW: 44 seats
- Your party's rule forbids governing with the Left

B. A MINORITY GOVERNMENT

- CDU, SPD and Greens: 31 seats
- It needs the Left and the BSW for every vote

C. LET THE AFD GOVERN

- The AfD alone: 39 seats. With the BSW: 44
- Your party's rule forbids working with the AfD

WHERE IT STANDS, EARLY NOVEMBER

- The CDU, SPD, Greens and the Left refused the AfD's invitation to talk. The BSW accepted
- Without the BSW it is 39 seats against 39, and the BSW says it will abstain
- The SPD, Greens, the Left and the BSW discussed a minister-president from outside the parties. The CDU stayed away
- Ulrich Siegmund, the AfD's lead candidate, will stand in December. On a third ballot a majority of the votes cast is enough

The latest:

Are populist right parties anti-democratic?

- **In general**, no. Most populist right parties favor free and fair elections (but, see Hungary as an exception).
- However, these parties are less supportive of **liberal democracy**
  - **Liberal Democracy:** Free speech, free press, right to protest, protections for minority opinions or identities, etc.
- Argue that the government should reflect the voice of the “true people”, and things like the bureaucracy and elite must be pushed aside
  - Might need to break some things to get the needed change



Italy: Why Meloni Won



Silvio Berlusconi, a former prime minister of Italy, at a rally of the right-wing alliance. Behind him: the logos of his own party and of the Brothers of Italy, the party of Giorgia Meloni, prime minister since 2022

- Her party's roots: the Italian Social Movement, founded by former fascists
- Shut out until 1994, when Silvio Berlusconi took it into government
- After 2011: technocrats and grand coalitions, built to avoid early elections
- 2021: every large party governs but hers
- 2022: her party wins 26%, up from 4% in 2018

Did office tame Meloni? Six fears, four years on

Erik Jones, a political scientist, two months into her government: "popular, scary, and competent, all at the same time."

THE FEAR, AND WHAT JONES SAW AFTER TWO MONTHS	HAPPENED?	FOUR YEARS ON
A fight with the EU over the budget First budget: "softer than her campaign rhetoric"	**No**	Tight budgets. Her former minister Raffaele Fitto is a vice-president of the European Commission
An end to arms for Ukraine More arms, backed by "most of Parliament"	**No**	The Associated Press: "steadfast support for Ukraine"
A hard line on migration Her response: "more bluster than action"	**Yes**	Asylum centers in Albania. And nearly 500,000 work visas for foreign workers over three years
A stronger executive, fewer checks She wants "a directly elected president"	**Tried**	Her bill for a directly elected prime minister stalled. March 2026: voters rejected her reform of the courts, 53% to 47%
Limits on protest and on rights A decree "seemed to threaten the right of assembly"	**Yes**	2025: heavier penalties at protests. 2024: a ban on surrogacy abroad
One more short-lived government "Likely to last longer" than her predecessors	**No**	September 2026: the longest-lasting government since World War II

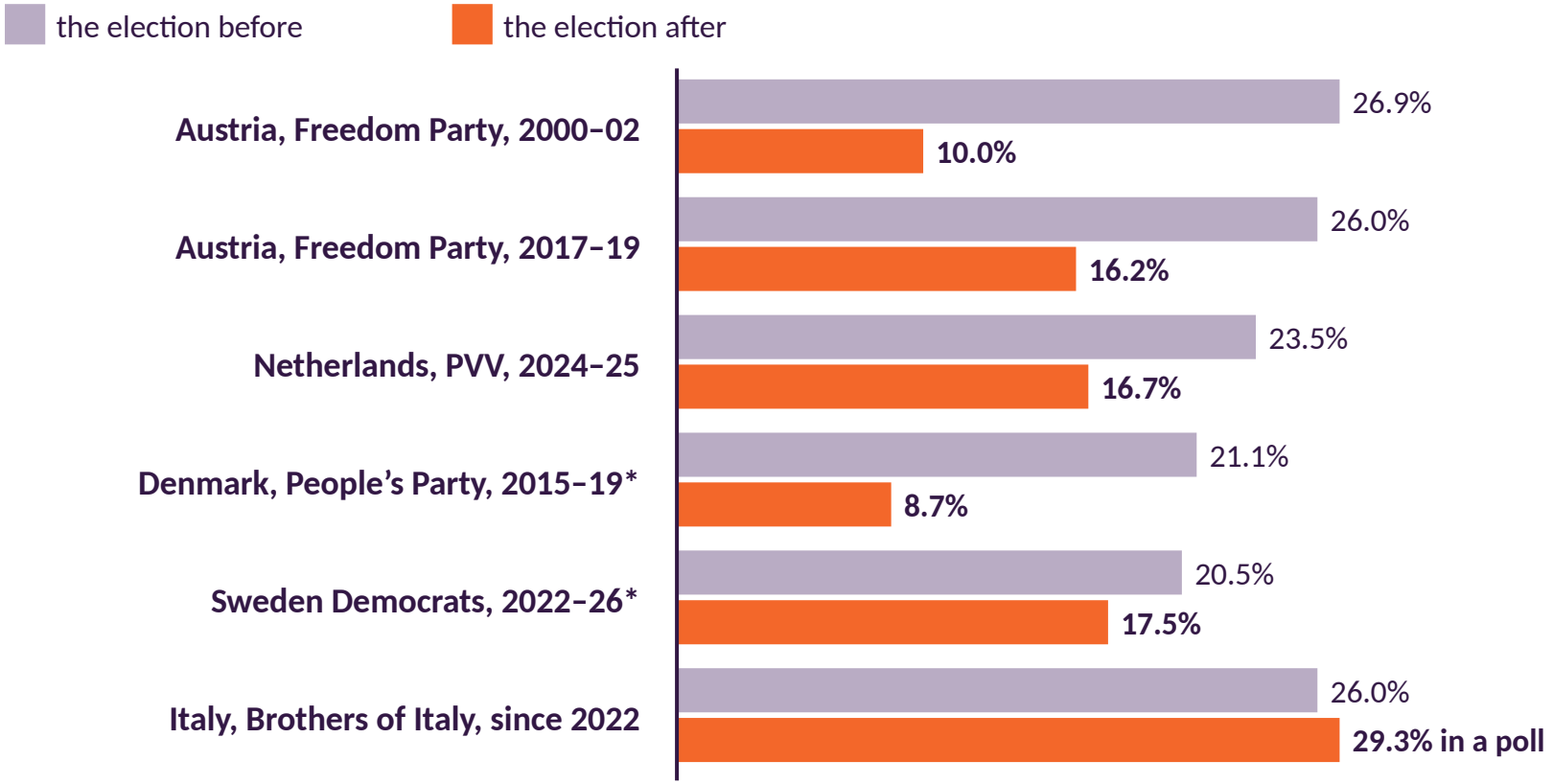
HANDS UP

Tamed? **Yes** **Partly** **No**

Jones's conclusion: "Democratically successful parties appear to be illiberal; elections serve primarily to delay confrontations between politicians and voters; and principled politicians are judged more by what they say than what they accomplish."

What office does to radical parties

Before the click: does a spell in government cost these parties votes?




De Telegraaf
VRIJDAG 6 JANUARI 2017
SPRAAKMAKEND DE GROOTSTE!
Bianca Krijgsman: 'Bucketlist is een vreselijk fenomeen'
GEERTS ANGELS
'Blij als een kind'

Geert Wilders, leader of the Dutch PVV, on a newspaper front page in 2017. His party joined the government in July 2024 and walked out eleven months later

** Supported the government from outside. The exception leads her government; the others were junior partners or outside supporters.*

Denmark: did copying work?

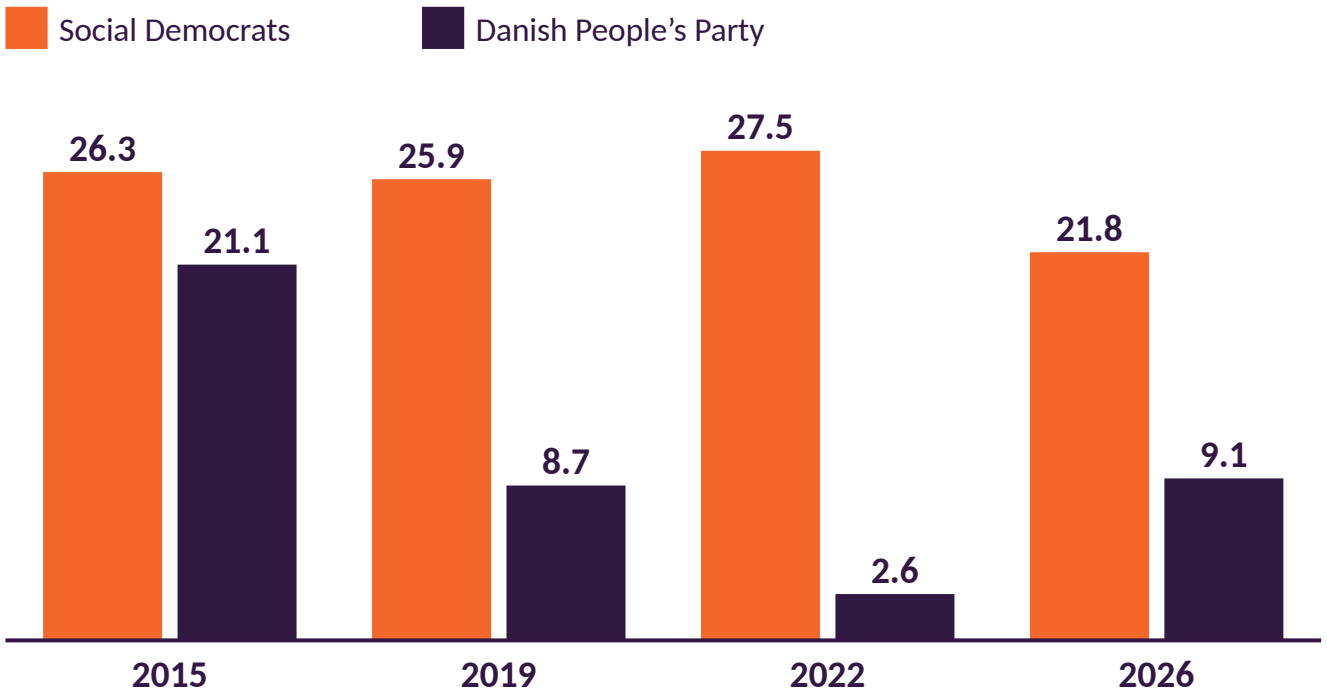


Mette Frederiksen, leader of Denmark's Social Democrats since 2015 and prime minister since 2019

THE SOCIAL DEMOCRATS' HARD LINE

- In opposition they voted to ban face veils and to take valuables from refugees at the border
- In office, the goal: "zero spontaneous asylum seekers"

From 2015 they took the radical right's line on immigration. Before the click: did it work?



2019 and 2022: the People's Party collapsed. 2026: it more than tripled its vote, and the Social Democrats had their worst result since 1903. They still lead the government.

Let it govern, or shut it out?

LET IT GOVERN: ITALY

- For: office brings limits (EU money, the markets, allies), and voters get a record to judge
- The risk: it uses office to loosen the checks on government

SHUT IT OUT: GERMANY

- For: no ministries for a party hostile to parts of liberal democracy
- The risk: it grows as the one real opposition, while its rivals' coalitions agree on little

HANDS UP

Which is riskier for democracy in the long run?

Letting it govern

Shutting it out

Key Points

- Three answers: shut it out, let it govern, take up its positions
- Junior partners and outside supporters lost votes. Meloni, who leads, has not
- Germany’s firewall kept the AfD out of office while its vote doubled
- Denmark’s hard line worked twice, then stopped working
- None of the three has made these parties go away

The Budget Bill

The Federal Republic of Clemson: the first governing session

The Budget Bill: how the session runs

MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS	WHO SPEAKS
0 to 5	The government presents the bill	The Finance minister, the PM or the Welfare minister, or shared
5 to 10	The opposition responds	The Populist Right's Finance spokesperson: 3 minutes. The Radical Left: 2
10 to 30	Amendments	Slips close at 5:00. The Speaker alternates the benches
30 to 35	The final vote, in seats	A majority of the votes cast passes the bill. A tie fails it



Germany's parliament, March 2025: 513 votes to 207 to loosen the constitution's limit on borrowing, for defense and infrastructure

ON YOUR DESK

- The Budget Bill
- The coalition agreement
- Your position paper
- Amendment slips

Legislation that fails stays failed. A government that loses its budget faces a confidence vote at the next session.

Amendments

THE RULES

- A change to a numbered measure, with its cost
- On a slip, handed to the Speaker by 5:00
- Seconded by an MP from a different party
- The Speaker alternates opposition and coalition
- One minute from the mover, one from the Finance minister, then a vote in seats

	MOVED BY	SECONDED BY	FOR	AGAINST	RESULT
1	?	?	?	?	?
2	?	?	?	?	?
3	?	?	?	?	?
4	?	?	?	?	?
5	?	?	?	?	?

For and against are counted in seats.

The final vote on the Budget Bill

	SEATS	FOR	AGAINST	ABSTAIN
Radical Left	7	?	?	?
Social Democrats	31	?	?	?
Greens	10	?	?	?
Liberals	15	?	?	?
Christian Democrats	18	?	?	?
Populist Right	19	?	?	?
Independents and splinters	0	?	?	?
Parliament	100	?	?	?

THE BUDGET

?

Passed or failed

A majority of the votes cast passes the bill; a tie fails it. If the budget fails, the government faces a confidence vote at the next session.